Amity Model United Nations I

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UNSC

United Nations Security Council

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Committee: United Nations Security Council

Topic: The Future of Nuclear Non-Proliferation

I. Introduction

The United Nations Security Council (UNSC) is one of the 6 main organs of the United Nations. It was established in 1945 following the end of WWII. Its main responsibility is the maintenance of international peace and security. The abilities held by the UNSC include the authority to investigate disputes, call for ceasefires, impose sanctions, authorize peacekeeping missions, and, in certain circumstances, approve the use of force to address threats to global stability. Due to these powers, the UNSC is generally considered the most influential body within the UN when responding to international crises.

The Security council is composed of 15 member states, and 5 of these are permanent members, often referred to as the “P5.” These are the United States, United Kingdom, France, Russia, and China. These were the major Allied powers at the end of WWII and were granted permanent seats as well as the power to veto substantive resolutions. The remaining 10 members are non-permanent and elected by the UN General Assembly for two-year terms, based on the region of the world they represent. These states currently include Bahrain, Colombia, Democratic Republic of the Congo, Denmark, Greece, Latvia, Liberia, Pakistan, Panama, and Somalia which ensure diversity by representing various geographical regions. This structure was created with the intention of balancing the influence of the most powerful states with broader representation internationally.

The veto power held by the permanent members is a defining feature of the security council, as any one of the P5can prevent the adoption of a substantive resolution, even if the majority of council members support it. While this mechanism was designed to ensure cooperation among the world's greatest powers, it has been a major source of controversy in the committee as it can prevent necessary action in major situations where international consensus exists but one major permanent member objects.

In addition to responding to armed conflict, many broader security challenges are addressed by the United Nations Security Council as they arise. These include terrorism, cyber threats, and the spread of nuclear weapons. Through sanctions regimes, monitoring bodies, and legally binding resolutions, the Security Council has addressed many nuclear proliferation concerns related to states such as North Korea and Iran. The UNSC also works closely with international institutions such as the International Atomic Energy Agency to monitor nuclear programs and enforce compliance with international agreements.

Because of its authority to pass binding resolutions and coordinate responses to security threats, the Security Council remains central to the global effort to prevent the spread of nuclear weapons with their United Nations Atomic Energy Committee. As technological developments, geopolitical tensions, and emerging nuclear states continue to challenge existing frameworks such as, the NPT (Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons), UNSC Resolution 1540, UNSC Resolution 1887, Security Assurances Framework (UNSC Resolution 984). Many of these frameworks support the general idea of reduction of support towards states or non-states that attempt to develop, acquire, manufacture, possess, transport, transfer, or use nuclear, chemical, or biological weapons, in particular for purposes that are related to terrorism.

II. Topic: The Future of Nuclear Non-Proliferation

A. Topic History

The proliferation of nuclear weapons constantly poses a grave threat to international peace and security. The United Nations Security Council (UNSC), entrusted with maintaining global peace, plays a pivotal role in preventing the spread of nuclear weapons and ensuring compliance with international nonproliferation norms. Nuclear nonproliferation became a global concern after the first use of nuclear weapons during WWII. In August 1945, the United States dropped atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki, which demonstrated the destructive power of nuclear weapons and sparked the international concern over their future spread.

After the war, nuclear weapons quickly became central to global security, and symbolic of power. In 1646 the United Nations Security Council began the process of implementing new programs and groups such as the United Nations Atomic Energy Commission in hopes of preventing future nuclear proliferation. It had the goal of eliminating nuclear weapons and regulating atomic energy. The commission proposed the Baruch plan to internationally regulate nuclear weapons. During the Cold War between the United States and the Soviet union, both countries amplified their efforts by expanding their nuclear arsenals, and additional states, including the United Kingdom, France, and China, developed nuclear weapons. This period marked the start of global discussions surrounding the prevention of further nuclear spread.

The confrontation between the United States and the Soviet Union during the Cuban Missile Crisis nearly caused a nuclear war. Soviet Union missiles were placed in Cuba and the United States created a naval blockade. This event ended up convincing world leaders that it was important to invest in stronger nuclear arms control and nonproliferation measures. Following that, the Nuclear Nonproliferation Treaty (NPT) was passed in 1968 and it is widely considered the most relevant and substantial piece of legislation related to the nonproliferation efforts. It had 3 main pillars that included nonproliferation, disarmament and peaceful nuclear energy. This was a major step in the right direction, but unfortunately some states, such as India, Pakistan, and Israel, never joined.

After the end of the Cold War, the UNSC became more active in enforcing nuclear nonproliferation. One of the first major cases occurred after the Gulf War in 1991, when it was discovered that Iraq had been secretly pursuing nuclear weapons. After this, the UNSC adopted stricter inspection and disarmament measures. Other challenges included, the nuclear program of North Korea, which withdrew from the NPT in 2003 and later conducted nuclear testing, concerns about Iran's nuclear program, which resulted in multiple UNSC sanctions beginning in 2006. These cases demonstrated the UNSC's growing role in monitoring nuclear programs, imposing sanctions, and enforcing compliance with international agreements.

In the 21st century, the UNSC has expanded efforts to prevent nuclear proliferation and nuclear terrorism. A key milestone was the adoption of the United Nations Security Council Resolution 1540 in 2004, which requires all states to prevent non-state actors (terrorist groups) from acquiring nuclear, chemical or biological weapons. Recent discussions in the UNSC focus on, preventing nuclear weapons development in unstable regions, ensuring compliance with the NPT, addressing emerging technologies and nuclear security risks and encouraging nuclear disarmament among existing nuclear powers.

B. Current Situation

Today, nuclear nonproliferation remains a major issue in international security. The global framework designed to prevent the spread of nuclear weapons is primarily built around the NPT, which currently has over 190 member states, and is widely considered the major cornerstone of the global nonproliferation regime. The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) supports the treaty. This helps monitor nuclear programs and ensure peace through nuclear energy.

Despite these efforts, several major challenges continue to threaten the effectiveness of the nonproliferation system. One of the most pressing issues involves the nuclear program of North Korea. The country withdrew from the NPT in 2003, and has since conducted multiple significant nuclear tests. The UNSC has responded by imposing numerous sanctions aimed at limiting North Korea's nuclear and missile development. However, negotiations have repeatedly stalled, and the country's nuclear arsenal continues to grow.

Another major concern is the nuclear program of Iran. In 2015, Iran had agreed to limit its nuclear activities under the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), an agreement with several world powers. However, after the United States withdrew from the deal in 2018, tensions increased and Iran began to expand their nuclear activities beyond the limits of the agreement, which raised significant concerns within the international community.

C. Questions to Consider

1. How effective has the treaty on the Nonproliferation of Nuclear Weapons been in preventing the spread of nuclear weapons, and what reforms might strengthen it in the future?
2. What role should the UNSC play in enforcing compliance with international nonproliferation agreements?
3. How should the international community address nuclear programs in states such as North Korea and Iran while avoiding further regional instability?
4. What measures can be taken to encourage countries outside of the NPT, such as India, Pakistan, and Israel, to participate in global nonproliferation frameworks?
5. How can the international community strengthen monitoring and verification systems through organizations like the International Atomic Energy Agency?
6. What steps can states take to prevent non-state actors or terrorist organizations from acquiring nuclear materials?
7. Should the modernization of nuclear arsenals by nuclear powers such as the United States, Russia, and China be addressed within the nonproliferation framework?
8. How can diplomacy, sanctions, and international cooperation be balanced to effectively discourage nuclear proliferation?
9. What role should peaceful nuclear energy programs play in the future of global nuclear governance?
10. How can the UNSC ensure that nuclear nonproliferation efforts remain effective in an increasingly multipolar international system?

D. Additional Resources

Disarmament | United Nations

https://montessori-mun.org/wp-content/uploads/2013/09/BG_SC_Nuclear_Security.pdf

Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT) | IAEA

Opinion | Can 50 Years of Minimizing Nuclear Proliferation Continue? - The New York Times

New START Treaty - United States Department of State